



A U.S. MILITARY honor guard rehearses for this week’s White House visit by Chinese President Xi Jinping. GRAEME SLOAN Getty Images

If not for China, oil prices might be worse

Iran war sent costs soaring. Trump can thank Xi’s policy that they aren’t higher.

By AAMER MADHANI

WASHINGTON — It could be much worse.

When President Trump launched his war against Iran in late February, energy analysts issued dire warnings that oil prices could more than double during a protracted conflict and urged investors and motorists to buckle up for a bumpy ride.

The war grinds on and oil prices certainly remain volatile. But the most dire projections have not come to pass more than six months into a conflict that has no end in sight.

Chinese President Xi Jinping, who is making a much-anticipated state visit to Washington this week, could make a credible argument that the world has his country’s energy strategy to thank for that.

It’s unclear how much the two leaders will discuss Iran during the visit, at a time when AI safety and competition are at the forefront. It also comes as Trump’s Republican Party faces pressure from voters over high gasoline prices, and as China’s buffer is being further tested as the war in the Middle East spreads.

Trump, who has sought to keep a fragile trade truce with Beijing intact, has been careful in public comments about differences with Xi over the country’s relationship with Iran.

“We’ve been free-riding off Beijing in a weird way,” said Rosemary Kelanic, director of the Middle East program at Defense Priorities, a Washington think tank. “China’s doing it because they understand that they’re on the train that Trump is driving off a cliff. If oil prices go way up, that hurts the global economy. If it hurts the global economy, it hurts them.”

China’s oil stockpile

Beijing spent years and billions of dollars amassing the world’s largest oil stockpile, building its strategic reserve to about 1.4 billion barrels by the end of last year, according to the U.S. Energy [See **Oil**, A9]

Pump cost stares voters in the face

While the president calls gas increases a small price to pay, drivers tend not to agree. **NATION**, A3

THE SYSTEM FAILED TO PROTECT HER

Nora Villanueva Campanor got a restraining order against her abusive ex — and still ended up dead

By Connor Sheets and Gabrielle LaMarr LeMee

He was working behind the Thrifty ice cream counter when they first met. She was 15 and shopping with her father and sister at a Rite Aid on Palmdale’s east side.

Wearing earrings, tight jeans and gel in his hair, 17-year-old Jesse Carrillo eyed Nora Villanueva Campanor as she shopped.

“He looks like a player,” her sister warned.

But Nora liked his style and soon she and Jesse were dating. A year later, she was pregnant.

Their daughter was born on Valentine’s Day in 2012. Nora was 17.

Nora and Jesse were married the following spring at a courthouse in Lancaster. Their second child, a son, was born a year after that.

The relationship had been troubled since the beginning. Carrillo was controlling and jealous, according to Nora’s family members. He put a tracker on her car and forbade her from even going to the gym, they said.

Nora’s sister, Jazmin Villanueva, said he got into shouting matches with Nora and once hit her mother and pushed her down several steps during a bad argument.

Nora’s loved ones knew she was being mistreated, but they said she didn’t talk about it because she didn’t want them to worry.

“She was a church girl. She was focused on school,” Jazmin said.

In April 2024, according to court records, Carrillo was arrested after Nora reported that their daughter said he had sexually abused her. Two days later, the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department released him from custody, citing insufficient evidence to charge him.

Then, after stalking her for four months, Carrillo abducted Nora and shot and killed her at an intersection in Lancaster.

She was one of at least 63 women killed in 2024 and 2025 in L.A. County with a former partner or close relative who was ar-

[See **Orders**, A6]

Voices PATT MORRISON COLUMNIST

El Niño threat is a rerun for L.A.

El Niño is coming for us.

It’s out there over the Pacific Ocean, waiting. Muscling up for the move.

It’s come this way before, and it overstayed its welcome. At intervals of 20 years and sometimes more often, it has lashed and splashed us, turned our living rooms into muddy aquariums, swept away our cars and houses, and sometimes hundreds of Angelenos.

So, when Sepulveda Boulevard becomes the Sepulveda River in a few months, and the TV news reporters pull on those

County prepares for flood threat

Crews are clearing massive amounts of accumulated sediment from reservoirs. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

yellow rain slickers for “Stormwatch ‘26,” remember that L.A. has starred in this movie before.

El Niño’s nastiest modern visit was on March 2, 1938, when a pair of storms hit the city of L.A. with 5.88 inches of rain in 24 hours. It rampaged for several days, and flooded the basin so devastatingly that the Os-

cars, scheduled for March 3, had to be postponed for a week because so many stars and filmmakers were marooned up in the canyons and on their ranches in the San Fernando Valley. More on death and destruction later.

We live in a perfect geological machine for flooding. The thousands of square miles of mountain watershed around us, the San Gabriels and the San Bernardino, are as steep as roller coasters, and the rain funnels off them in tumults. The one-day rainfall record in California, and the fourth-highest ever in the [See **Morrison**, A4]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

MISSING THE MARK

Cameron Dicker (11) watches his field-goal try go wide during a 26-14 loss to the Raiders at SoFi Stadium, dropping the Chargers to 0-2. **SPORTS**, D1

ICE agent shoots man in Texas

The unnamed person was in serious but stable condition after being hit in the torso in Austin. Protesters quickly turn out. **NATION**, A3

Sheeran clarifies stance on Gaza

Singer opens his solo concert in Philadelphia saying the situation is “catastrophic and unjustifiable.” **ENTERTAINMENT**, E3

Weather

Some sun. L.A. Basin: 79/65. **B5**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



California still battling Trump over elections

State targeted with subpoenas in federal inquiry into alleged noncitizen voting.

By KEVIN RECTOR

With the deadline for mailing out millions of California ballots nearing, Los Angeles County’s top election official welcomed the U.S. Postal Service’s recent assurance that it will process those ballots as normal — not under the untested new vetting system backed by President Trump and rejected as unworkable by the U.S. Supreme Court.

“That certainly serves as a stabilizing force, as we’re literally weeks away from mailing the ballots,” said Dean Logan, head of the L.A. County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk’s office.

Still, there are other Trump administration challenges to deal with, he said — including unsubstantiated public claims of widespread voter fraud, refusals by top-ranking officials to rule out

deployments of armed federal agents to polling places, and behind-the-scenes criminal probes into local voter lists.

Since March, Logan’s office has received a series of federal grand jury subpoenas demanding voter registration and other information on dozens of individuals who the Trump administration says may not be U.S. citizens, Logan confirmed to The Times.

Logan said his office is now in the “interesting place” of having to comply with the subpoenas despite suspecting that the Department of Homeland Security relied on inaccurate or outdated voter information to compile the names to investigate.

“We’re responding appropriately as directed through a subpoena, but that doesn’t afford the dialogue for us to get the background on what they’re looking for and how they came up with the names that they did,” Logan said.

The subpoenas appear to mirror others received by [See **Elections**, A4]

Opposition grows to a Paramount merger settlement

By MEG JAMES

Tensions flared on the eve of a critical week ahead for Paramount Skydance’s proposed \$11-billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery, amid new urgency for talks aimed at settling antitrust litigation brought by California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta and 11 other states.

Over the weekend, opposition intensified to a proposed settlement as details trickled out, including a proposal to establish a bipartisan editorial board to monitor cable news channel CNN, one of Warner’s premier properties that Paramount Chief Executive David Ellison would control along with CBS News.

It was unclear Sunday whether a proposed settlement would require Paramount to sell off assets — something Bonta repeatedly has insisted upon. Critics of the deal urged Bonta and other state attorneys general to resist pressure to reach a settlement that

would allow Ellison’s deal to move forward.

“State Attorneys General, please hang tough against the giant proposed Paramount-Warner Brothers merger,” Rep. Jamie Raskin (D-Md.) wrote on social media late Saturday.

“Paramount, run by the Ellisons, should not own both CBS and CNN. California must not cave and take a deal that leaves both under the same owner,” Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Fremont) wrote.

Bonta and Ellison have made progress in the talks in recent days, according to four people familiar with the matter not authorized to speak publicly.

However, New York’s Letitia James and at least two other attorneys general who joined Bonta’s lawsuit in July privately have expressed reservations about the proposed compromises, believing they don’t go far enough to mitigate concerns about the power Paramount-Warner Bros. would wield over the film and TV industries should the [See **Paramount**, A8]

Feds seek predators in child sex abuse network

By BRITTNY MEJIA AND CLARA HARTER

In the early morning darkness, FBI agents broke down the door of a two-story townhome in Los Angeles. Their target was a 28-year-old man they linked to a sprawling online network of predators that targets young girls across the globe.

“I’m right here,” Jose Henry Ayala Casimiro called out, as agents swarmed the San Fernando Valley home he shared with his parents and his younger brother. “What’s going on?”

Agents handcuffed Ayala and searched the house, seizing his desktop computer, gaming consoles, phone and any other devices they suspected he may have used to communicate with victims, his brother recalled. Ayala’s parents, roused from sleep, watched in stunned silence, unaware of the extent of their son’s alleged crimes, which were laid out in a 62-page criminal complaint

filed in federal court.

In an interview with federal authorities, a teenage victim accused Ayala of committing extreme acts of cruelty. She reported that he made young girls he met online throw up on camera and lick up the vomit. That he pushed others to put cigarette butts out on their skin. That he had others go even further and carve his name into their bodies.

Authorities said Ayala was driven by his participation in a loose online network known as “764,” whose members coerce children into performing self-harm and sexual acts on camera to gain status with other members of the network.

Last year’s raid of Ayala’s family home has played out repeatedly across the nation, as federal authorities hunt down other members of this growing online subculture, also referred to as Nihilistic Violent Extremism, which weaponizes digital platforms to exploit and [See **Abuse**, A5]